THE GODS GO GREEN

A BACK-TO-NATURE STRATEGY COUPLED WITH THE USE OF MODERN TECHNOLOGY IS MAKING THE TIRUMALA TEMPLE A TRENDSETTER

By Amarnath K. Menon



The world's richest Hindu shrine is going organic. The hilltop Sri Venkateswara temple is now using indigenous cow products and produce from chemical-free natural farming for all its sacred rituals. Be it the butter used for lighting the lamps or the mix for its famous laddoo *prasadam*, everything comes via the organic route.

Temple custodian Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) says it is tapping technology to process the 950 kg of flowers offered every day—they are dried and recycled as incense sticks and other value-added products. This is apart from the spinoff for ayurvedic products developed from *panchagavvya*, using cow dung, urine, milk, curd and ghee.

Indeed, the *desi* cow is the centrepiece of the TTD initiative. The temple management has expanded its dairy farm and started the Navaneeta Seva—an offering of butter produced by traditional churning of curd prepared from *desi* cow milk from their *gaushalas* (cow shelters).

The 60 kg of butter used for *naivedyam* (food consecrated for the deity) and as oil for the temple lamps daily also comes from the *gaushala*. Some 108 indigenous cows of breeds such as the Gir, Sahiwal, Kankrej and Tarparkar have been added to the stock. Another 500 are on the list, but the outbreak of lumpy skin viral disease in cattle across the country has put a temporary pause to additions to the herd. The TTD's Gosamrakshana Trust has received